

MAGIC TRICK

The courtroom was old.

Wood everywhere. Dark panels lining the walls, worn smooth by decades of hands and shoulders leaning against them. A building designed to intimidate—to make you feel small standing in it. The carpet was new, though. Someone's attempt at modernisation that only made the rest of it look older. Like putting fresh paint on a coffin.

I'd been through this process before. Plenty of times. But always for the smaller stuff—the appearances, the adjournments, the legal theatre that happens before anything real gets decided. This was different.

This was sentencing.

Kate was already at the defence table when they brought me in.

Pencil skirt. White blouse. Heels that clicked on the floor when she walked. Young—couldn't have been more than a few years older than me— but she carried herself like she'd been doing this for decades. You had to, I suppose. Criminal defence isn't a job for people who flinch.

We knew each other well by now. Too well, probably. She could pick me out from behind in a crowded courthouse. Not a connection you brag about, but it was there.

The prosecutor sat across from Kate. Police badge. Stack of folders. The look of someone who'd already decided how this should end.

And me—I was in the box. Defendant's dock.

Positioned between the judge's bench and Kate's table like I was the fulcrum everything balanced on.

The gallery was sparse.

A few randoms waiting for their own cases to be called. And then my people—my brother, who'd wagged school to be there. Si. Stacey.

They weren't looking at me. Not directly. You don't stare when someone's waiting to hear how long—you glance. Quick looks when the attention is elsewhere. Silent shorthand between people who know each other too well to need words.

My brother was fifteen. Just a kid, really—though he wouldn't have agreed with that description. He sat with that particular stillness teenagers have when they're trying to look older than they are. Trying to be steady for me, maybe. Or just trying to understand what was happening.

Si had that expression he always wore when shit got serious—half smirk, half something else. The look of someone who knew the score but was still hoping for a different outcome.

Stacey just sat there. Quiet. Watching. The kind of watching that says everything words can't.

The judge spoke.

I don't remember all of it. The legal language—it washes over you after a while. You catch the words that matter and let the rest blur into background noise.

Eighteen charges.

That part I remember. Grand theft auto. Cultivation with intent. Burglary. The list went on, each one adding weight to the air.

Two years. Five years. Six years.

The numbers started stacking. I was doing the maths in my head—the way you do when someone's talking about your life in numbers. Adding. Calculating. Watching the total climb.

At four years, something in my chest tightened. Not panic—I don't do panic.

Just... acknowledgment.

Recognition of how deep this hole was getting.

This is not fucking good.

I didn't let it show. Kept my face empty. Eyes on the judge. Stacey was in my peripheral vision—I could see her expression shifting, the worry settling in, making me want to look away. I didn't. Held the line.

The judge kept reading.

When he finished with the charges, he paused.

Looked at me over his glasses. The way teachers look at students who've disappointed them.

Then he started talking about me.

My offending history. My age. The pattern. The trajectory. A stranger in robes telling me who I was based on paper. Based on dates and charges and whatever Kate had managed to say in my defence.

I stood there and took it.

Just another day at the office.

The bailiffs were already moving before he finished.

That's how you know it's done. The uniforms shift. The energy changes. Everyone starts preparing for the next part—the part where you stop being a defendant and start being a number.

I looked at the gallery.

My brother. Fifteen years old. Wagging school to watch his older brother get sent down. I mouthed the words at him:

Catch ya on the flipside.

Si. My best mate.

Peace out, ballbag.

Stacey. I didn't have words for her. Just the look. The one that says *I'll be alright* even when you're not sure that's true.

I raised my hand. Casual military salute.

A goodbye without making it heavy.

Then I turned and walked.

A bailiff's hand settled on my elbow—not rough.

Just firm. Guiding.

The door closed behind me with a sound like a walk-in chiller sealing shut.

* * *

On the other side, the room was small.

Maybe two and a half metres wide. Three and a half deep.

A desk stretched across the width of it, bolted to the floor—because apparently even furniture couldn't be trusted in here.

The walls were the same bureaucratic beige as every other government building I'd ever been dragged through.

Three doors.

The one behind me led back to the courtroom. The one to my left led down to the basement—the holding cells, custody, the place you go when you're no longer a person with a name but a body with a case number.

The one in front of me, on the other side of the desk, was where Kate would come through.

I sat down.

The chair wasn't bolted, which felt like a small victory.

Fifteen minutes.

That's how long I waited. Felt longer. Time moves differently when you've just heard years attached to your name and everything around you is designed to make you feel like cargo.

The internal monologue wasn't much.

You've gone and fucked this one up.

That was about it. No spiralling. No bargaining. Just acknowledgment.

The same way you'd note you'd missed a turn. Statement of fact.

File it away. Move on.

I stared at the desk. Counted the scratches in the surface. Wondered how many other people had sat in this exact chair, waiting for their lawyer to walk through that door and tell them what came next.

The door opened.

Kate walked in with a stack of folders under her arm and a look on her

face that didn't match the situation.

Pleased with herself. Like she'd just talked her way out of a parking ticket—not watched her client get sentenced.

She sat down across from me. Found my folder in the stack without hesitation. Started pulling paperwork.

I watched her for a second.

"What the fuck are you so happy about?"

Not angry. More confused. A half-laugh underneath it. Like I'd missed something—or was seconds away from becoming the joke.

She looked up. That smile still there.

"You got *concurrent* sentencing."

She said it like it was obvious. Like I should've been celebrating already.

"Concurrent?"

"Mm-hmm."

She went back to the paperwork. Legal aid forms. Fee schedules.

The administrative shit that follows you wherever they move you next.

I sat there.

Concurrent.

The word rattled around in my head, bumping into things, not quite landing. I'd heard it before. Thought I knew what it meant. But standing before the judge, watching the years stack up—two, five, six—I'd been doing the maths one way. Adding. Stacking. *Consecutive*. That was the word I'd been thinking of.

"Wait."

Kate looked up.

"Is *concurrent* the good one?"

She paused. Just for a second.

Then the smile widened into something almost like a laugh.

"Sure is."

The relief didn't hit the way you'd expect.

No flood of emotion. No weight lifting off my shoulders. Just a recalculation. A reframing. The numbers rearranging themselves into something survivable.

"Fucken sic."

Then the next thought:

"Wait—so how long then?"

Kate set down her pen.

"A year. Maybe less."

"I'm pushing for home detention at the six-week mark."

A year.

Not five.

Not six.

One.

"Fuck yes, ya good bitch."

She laughed. Actual laughter. The professional mask slipped for a second.

"Not a problem. That's what I'm here for."

She slid the paperwork across the desk.

Consent documents. The usual stack that follows every court appearance like a paper trail of your own bad decisions.

I didn't read any of it.

Kate was my lawyer. Reading the paperwork was her job. If she said sign, I signed. That was the deal. Now, if it had been paperwork from the cops—that was different. I'd read every word, then hand it to Kate to read again before I put my name anywhere near it.

Trust calibrated by experience.

I signed where she pointed. Initialled where she indicated. Let the pen move without thinking too hard about what I was agreeing to.

"The home detention."

"Yeah?"

"Don't get your hopes up."

"You've breached every bail condition you've ever been given. Some of them multiple times."

I nodded.

"The board's going to look at that," she said, gathering up the forms.

She wasn't wrong. My history with conditions was shit. Every time they'd given me a leash, I'd found a way to slip it. Not because I was trying to make a point—just because that's how I operated. Rules were suggestions. Boundaries were challenges.

That doesn't play well at parole hearings.

"Worth a shot though, yeah?"

"We'll see," she said.

I didn't tell Stacey about the home detention possibility.

Not that day.

Protecting her from hope that might collapse. The same way I'd protected myself when the sentence came down—armour up, expect the worst, let the good news be a surprise if it comes.

But we'll get to that.

In that moment—sitting across from Kate in the holding room, paperwork signed, the word *concurrent* finally meaning what it was supposed to mean—I let myself feel something.

Not relief exactly.

More like... recalibration.

One year.

I could do one year.

I'd been through worse.

... Or had I?

* * *

The prison was full, so they held me at the local police station instead. Two weeks in limbo—sentenced, but not inside yet. Not outside either.

There were three of us. All sentenced. All waiting for beds to open up.

They put us in the day room, an area normally reserved for weekend holds—the Friday-night arrests waiting around until court opened again on Monday. It had shower stalls, a toilet and an outdoor enclosure hemmed in by brick walls so high the only thing visible above them was a square of sky.

Two tables were bolted to the floor.

Concrete everywhere.

Commercial-grade cleaner hung in the air, that institutional chemical smell that never quite covered what it was meant to. The place stayed cold, with a faint dampness underneath it that you couldn't see but could definitely feel.

And everything echoed.

Every noise had nowhere to go. It hit concrete, brick, steel, then came back at you half a beat later.

During the day, the lights went out at sunrise, which would have been fine if there had been any decent natural light. There wasn't.

Whatever daylight made it through the outdoor enclosure came in flat and grey. You'd sit there for hours in that half-dark, watching it shift across the concrete while the sun moved somewhere above walls you couldn't see over.

You heard the station more than you saw it.

Keys moving along the corridor. Locks opening and closing. Heavy steel doors slamming somewhere out of sight, the impact travelling through the building before the echo reached us.

Our mattresses were on the floor, spread into three corners. Three guys giving each other whatever passed for personal space.

The other two were Māori.

One of them I can't remember the name of now—a shorter guy with long hair, early twenties, in for burglary.

The other was Mara.

Six foot. Medium build. Half European. Short hair.

Well-spoken. In for fraud.

He was also a heroin addict. High-functioning. On the methadone programme.

You wouldn't have known by looking at him.

After a few days of yarning, mostly because there was fuck-all else to do with the hours, we worked out he was Stacey's cousin.

Second or third cousin, something distant.

Small fucking world.

Weekend holds came and went around us. Friday in. Monday out. They left their rubbish behind. Spat in the outdoor area.

We stayed.

A few short altercations came with them. Nothing major.

After about a week, the cops worked out we weren't causing them trouble. They started leaving the day-room door open, giving us access to the corridor, the little kitchen used for inmate food and the blood-test room.

Coffee and tea whenever we wanted.

Mara's methadone arrived daily.

Same ritual every time.

A sergeant came to the day-room door and called him over. Mara took the bottle, drank under supervision, opened his mouth for inspection, then handed the empty bottle back.

Supervised consumption. Standard protocol.

One day, we devised a plan.

The blood-test room had clean needles.

With three of us, it wasn't hard to get one out of there.
One distracted, one took it, one watched the corridor.
We had nothing but time to work out very small problems.
Mara handled the rest.

He positioned two cups in the ablution area, just beyond sight from the main area. One held water. The other was empty.

When the sergeant arrived with the dose, Mara went through the routine exactly as expected.

Bottle up. Drink. Nothing hurried. Nothing suspicious.

Then he asked for some water.

Casual. Polite.

The sergeant agreed.

Mara stepped into the ablution area.

Three seconds, maybe.

Long enough to empty the methadone into the waiting cup, take the cup of water and walk straight back out.

He raised the bottle again, pretending to finish what was no longer in it, then took a sip of water to wash it down.

Mouth open. Empty.

Bottle. Empty.

Cup. Empty.

Everything the sergeant expected to see.

He nodded, collected the bottle and left.

Me and the other guy held it together until he was gone.

The sergeant had been standing right there.

He hadn't glanced away. Hadn't wandered off.

He'd watched Mara comply with every part of the procedure.

Except the part that mattered.

He'd been standing there watching a magic trick.

Mara looked at us and grinned.

I'd never had anything injected into a vein before.

Pills, powders, smoke—sure. Needles had never entered the equation, and downers weren't really my thing anyway.

Fuck it. Why not. Had nothing else to do.

Mara prepared a small dose of the methadone.

I sat on the edge of the bench seat while he knelt beside me.

I watched him draw the methadone into the syringe. He tapped the barrel, working the air bubbles upward, then eased the plunger forward until a bead of liquid gathered at the needle tip.

I was lean then. Muscular. The veins in my arms stood out clearly.

Mara noticed. Got a little excited about it. Plenty to work with.
I squeezed my fist tight and one of them bulged beneath the surface.
He tied me off and found it.
I didn't look away.

The needle slid in. A sharp prick. No real pain.

What I remember more clearly is the intrigue. The anticipation. I'd never done it before and I wanted to see exactly what was happening.

Mara drew the plunger back a fraction.

My blood entered the syringe.

A thin red current curled through the methadone, briefly distinct inside the barrel before beginning to disperse through the dose.

No hesitation on my end.

I wasn't fearful of much at that stage of my life.

Mara started pressing the plunger down.

And the wave hit before it finished.

Euphoria. Immediate.

No gradual build. No waiting for something to happen. It was already happening.

Heavy and warm.

A few seconds earlier I was sitting in a cold police-station day room surrounded by concrete, steel and echoes. Then none of those hard edges seemed particularly important.

We moved back to the table.

A little nausea surfaced, hung around just long enough to register, then disappeared.

I was talking. I remember that much.

I rested my head against my hand mid-sentence.

And then I was gone.

What felt like a blink was hours.

The light had changed.

Late-afternoon daylight was filtering through the outdoor enclosure, a different shade of grey from before. My lunch was sitting beside me on the table.

Mara had collected it when it came through.

I lifted my head.

For me, the conversation hadn't ended.

I started to pick up exactly where I'd left off—mid-sentence, mid-thought—with no real comprehension yet that hours had passed.

Mara was sitting across from me, watching.

"Oh, he's back."

Calm. Amused. Like I'd stepped out for a smoke and wandered back in.

Then I noticed the lunch, the light, the fact that the afternoon had moved on without me.

Mara had grabbed my food and kept an eye on me while the high worked through, making sure the first-timer didn't stop breathing.

* * *

Two weeks passed.

Then they moved me.

First of the three to go.

I heard Mara once more inside.

Couldn't see him. Just his voice carrying from another yard during unlock after he'd spotted me walking past.

A few words shouted across concrete.

That was it.

The other guy, I never saw again.

Mara and I caught up on the outside after release.